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A MUSICIAN'S SWAN SONG

A month and a half after his death, Zubeen Garg's final film has turned theatres across India into spaces of collective tribute

The lights come on, and the end credits of the just-released Assamese film *Roi Roi Binale (*Tears Still Flow*)* fade into silence. The audience sits frozen, eyes red, cheeks streaked with tears. Two young women sob and hug each other, an older lady wipes her face with her dupatta, and a group of men linger in the last row, trying to hide what's written all over their teary faces.

For this crowd of Assamese residents in Gurugram, the heartbreak isn't about the film itself, but the fact that this is the last time they will see Zubeen Garg—the voice of their home state—alive on screen. The multifaceted singer, who drowned while swimming in Singapore a month and a half ago, left behind a void that runs deep. Over three decades, he recorded more than 38,000 songs in 40 languages, directed and acted in films, and championed social and environmental causes.

In the film, which he wrote, scored and starred in, Zubeen plays a blind singer whose defiance mirrors his own. His mannerisms, dialogues and philosophy of living fearlessly reflect his real-life persona. The title song reimagines his 1998 track of the same name, layering nostalgia and a cinematic sweep rarely seen in Assamese cinema. Certain scenes—his monologue on mortality, his love for the sea—now feel uncannily prophetic.

Finishing the film after his death tested the crew, logistically and emotionally. "The background music and dubbing were incomplete, and we had to ensure that everything reflected Zubeen's musical style and creative vision," says co-producer Shyamantak Gautam. "We brought in sound experts from Mumbai and used AI to recreate Zubeen's voice for the dubbing." The team managed to complete and release the film on the planned date of October 31.



Since then, *Roi Roi Binale* has packed theatres not just across Assam but in 46 Indian cities, rewriting the reach of cinema from the Northeast. "The emotional value is driving the viewership, but the film would have succeeded on its own as well," says Gautam. *Roi Roi Binale* feels less like a film release and more like Zubeen Garg's final concert—one where the curtain falls, but the music never really stops. ■

—Satarupa Paul



BIJU BORO

***Roi Roi Binale* feels less like a film release and more like Zubeen Garg's final concert**

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Seeing the Unseen

With *Working Girls,* filmmaker **Paromita Vohra** turns her lens on India's blue-collar women, crafting an empathetic portrait of feminist resilience

Indefatigable multihyphenate Paromita Vohra has been travelling across India, screening her new docu *Working Girls*, a continuation of her relentless investigation into urban feminisms that began with her 2002 production *Unlimited Girls.*

The 135-minute film tracks blue-

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